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chapter 12

Pan-Asian Buddhism and the Bodhisattva Cult in Champa

John Guy

Southeast Asia in the late first millennium was enamoured with the Mahayanist concept of the Buddhist princely saviour, the Bodhisattva whose intervention could assist the devotee in attaining merit to achieve *moksa* — liberation from the cycle of rebirth — in one's lifetime. The immediacy of this promise ensured the popularity of this particular faith, especially among the ruling elites, who came increasingly to identify with the personage of the "princely saviour" but who also were drawn to the advocacy of esoteric powers espoused by practitioners of *tantra*, in its myriad forms. Whilst in earlier centuries the exercising of tantric powers had been the domain of Hindu tantric masters (*siddhas*), beginning around the late seventh and eighth centuries we witness growing evidence of some of these individuals being Mahayana Buddhists, notably practitioners of *Mantrayana*. The latter employed the enactment of ritual mandalas (circles of divinities) and the recitation of sacred formulas (*mantra*).¹

The association of the Mahayanist Bodhisattva cults in Southeast Asia and the rise of esoteric Buddhism would seem to be closely linked. Much of the evidence for this lies in the manner in which Mahayana Buddhism in late first-millennium Southeast Asia came under the direct patronage of the ruling households. Indeed, it appears to have attracted this political support as a direct consequence of the powers attributed to

advanced tantric practitioners claiming to perform acts of magic and sorcery advantageous to the rulers of the day. *Mantrayana*, and later *Yogini Tantra*, were regarded as powerful tools employed in underpinning the power of the state and deflecting threats to that power.

A number of seventh-century inscriptions from the region display a familiarity with esoteric Buddhist knowledge and the paramount role of the Bodhisattva as personal saviour, as well as a belief in the power of *mantra* and *yantra* (magico-sacred diagrams) to both protect and punish. The most explicitly Buddhist in content is the Tulang Tuwo stele (684) from Palembang in southern Sumatra, in which the Bodhisattva Vajrapani appears to be invoked. In the Telaga Batu stele from the same area and around the same period, we witness the use of spells and invocations to punish disloyalty.² Already the two principal roles of esoteric Buddhism were in evidence, namely to save souls and protect the state. Mahayana Buddhism in turn prospered under the benevolence of royal patronage, as witnessed by the archaeological record of monuments built in its honour. It is revealing that of the Buddhist temples built in the eighth and ninth centuries in Southeast Asia — Java, Sumatra, pre-Angkorean Cambodia, Dvaravati and Champa — are all known from their epigraphic records to have been royally-endowed structures, and in probability this was universally the case.

The late seventh and eighth centuries witnessed some of the greatest teachers and translators of this new Buddhist knowledge spending time in the courts of Southeast Asia kingdoms. Following in the tradition of the early fifth-century Chinese pilgrim Faxian and the Kashmiri Buddhist teacher Gunavarman, both of whom resided for some time in Srivijaya and visited some Cham territories (Linyi?), Chinese pilgrims and Indian Buddhist scholars regularly sojourned in Southeast Asia, usually on route to China. Others settled or at least spent some years in various locations, engaged in tuition and translation. The Indian pundit Punyodana, an exponent of Vajrayana Buddhism (to be discussed in more detail below), went to China in 655, and in 663 was well received back in Southeast Asia, including a pre-Angkorean kingdom.³ A generation later the Indian monk Vajrabodhi (670–741) and his disciple Amoghavajra (705–74) spent time in either Sumatra or Java. Even in the eleventh century Srivijaya could attract such a Buddhist luminary as Atisha, a leading exponent of the *Hevajra tantra*; the latter text was therefore very probably circulating in Southeast Asia around the same time that it was being taken up in Himalayan Buddhist esoteric circles. An understanding of these new Buddhist texts enabled those initiated into the “secret knowledge” embodied therein to wield great power at Southeast Asian courts.

Paramount in the assembly of saviours was Avalokiteśvara, the embodiment of compassion. Lokeśvara, as he is widely identified in Southeast Asian inscriptions of the period, was clearly “first among equals” and acquired a cult status little short of that of the Buddha himself. Bodhisattvas also came to represent the measure of beauty, the embodiment of both the concept and canons of idealized beauty. In the mid-ninth century a delegation of “*Man*” 蠻 (barbarians) from mainland Southeast Asia to the Tang court at Chang’an were admired for their appearance and rich dress, “as splendid as princely Bodhisattvas”.⁴ The Indian convention of representing the Buddhist saviour as heavily bejewelled in princely dress clearly resonated with local rulers, who no doubt saw in these Buddhas-to-be a role model for their own kingship.

The *Tangshu*, written around this time, provides an unusually favourable description of the Cham kingdom(s), singling out for praise their devotion to the Buddha: “They have written characters. They rejoice in the Way of the Buddha, and smelt gold and silver for images, the largest sometimes ten spans around.”⁵ The late seventh-century Chinese pilgrim Yijing provides the earliest specific information on Buddhism practised in Cham territory: “In this country [Linyi] Buddhists generally belong to the Aryasammitinikaya, and there are a few followers of the Sarvastivadanikaya.”⁶ Yijing’s observations are valuable because his travels coincided with the blossoming of Vajrayana teachings in India and their rapid dissemination eastward. It is in this period that we begin to see the appearance of forms of Buddhist imagery — notably sculptures and portable votive tablets — in which the cult of the Bodhisattva is gaining prominence.

The archaeological record makes clear that Champa in the mid-ninth century was a vibrant centre for the practice of Mahayana Buddhism. As this paper will demonstrate, the evidence for this can be traced through the central and southern regions of Vietnam in the former Cham territories of Amaravati and Vijaya, corresponding to the modern provinces of Quảng Nam, Quảng Ngãi, Bình Định and Phú Yên. The economic rise of the Cham principalities of Kauthara and Panduranga further to the South in the late eighth and ninth centuries, stimulated by international trade, appears to have facilitated this process. Close trade links with Java and other parts of insular Southeast Asia would have facilitated participation in this new wave of Mahayanist activity.

Recent finds of sculptures and votive tablets in this region demonstrate a degree of integration into the Buddhist diaspora. A recently discovered stele, carved on the reverse of an unfinished *linga*-basin, shows a Buddha installed on a lotus, flanked by *chaityas/stupas* in the convention most

closely associated with the Buddhist art of the Mon Dvaravati culture of lower and central Thailand (Fig. 1). It closely resembles a small stone plaque depicting a similar scene dated to around the seventh century, from Ratburi in lower Central Thailand, and the silhouettes of the *stupas* depicted are essentially the same as those found on the Buddhagupta stele from Kedah in peninsular Malaysia (Figs. 4, 5). Although the early Buddhist landscape of southern India has been almost entirely erased, small bronze replica *stupas*, made to serve as reliquaries or to house the ashes of revered teachers, confirm that this was the prevalent *stupa* form in the later first millennium and beyond.⁷ Clay mouldings of miniature devotional icons recently unearthed at other riverine sites on the Vietnamese coast point to the penetration of Buddhism into the Cham centres of power (Figs. 2, 3).⁸ Undoubtedly further evidence will emerge in due course from provinces further south.



Fig. 1 Relief depicting the meditative Buddha on a lotus support, flanked by two *chaityas/stupas* with multiple umbrellas; inscribed. Excavated at a hill shrine site, Tuy Hoà, Phú Yên Province, Vietnam, ca. 7th–8th century. Sandstone.
(Photograph by Trần Kỳ Phương)



Fig. 2 Buddhist moulded devotional icon with a meditating Buddha seated on a lotus, flanked by *chaityas/stupas* with lion supports. Terracotta. Provincial Museum of Quảng Ngãi, Vietnam.
(Photograph by Trần Kỳ Phương)



Fig. 3 Buddhist moulded devotional icon with a meditating Buddha seated on throne with *makara* cross bar, flanked by *chaityas/stupas*. Terracotta. Provincial Museum of Quảng Ngãi, Vietnam.
(Photograph by Trần Kỳ Phương)

Fig. 4 Miniature stele depicting a Buddha meditating beneath an honorific umbrella, flanked by a *dharmacakrastambha* and a *chaitya/stupa*. Mon-Dvaravati, ca. 8th century. (Ratburi National Museum, Thailand)



Fig. 5 The Buddhagupta inscription. Locally carved stele found in association with brick temple remains, Muda River area, Bujang Valley, Kedah, Malaysia, ca. 5th–6th century. (Indian Museum, Calcutta)

In Champa, Buddhism never succeeded in eclipsing Hinduism as a court and state religion. Nonetheless, it did enjoy sustained patronage, and during a brief heyday it assumed centre-stage in the reign of King Indravarman II. This was in the late ninth century when he established his new capital of Indrapura in the northern Cham territories, with his spiritual centre at Đồng Dương, 20 kilometres to the Southeast of Mỹ Sơn. Much of the finest Bodhisattva imagery extant from Cham culture appears to belong to this period. A newly-discovered gilt bronze standing Avalokiteśvara and some related finds, to be discussed later, bear witness to this (Figs. 14, 16).

THE BUDDHIST DIASPORA

The spread of Buddhism throughout Southeast Asia parallels the adoption of early Hinduism, most notably the cult of Siva, which from its beginnings in the region was intimately linked to the emergence of the institution of kingship. The earliest Sanskrit inscriptions in Southeast Asia — from Kutei (eastern Kalimantan) and Võ Cạnh (central coastal Vietnam), both of which are assigned on epigraphic evidence to the late fourth century — are concerned with the welfare of the authors, evidently local rulers. The Võ Cạnh inscription employs forms of speech which call for benevolence in rule, phrases that have been interpreted as being imbued with Buddhist values.⁹ These are difficult to interpret, however, and it remains the case that the first securely identified Buddhist inscriptions date to around a century later, the legacy of Indian merchants recording their thanksgiving for a safe passage. They are associated with the merchant community who used the riverine settlements in the Bujang Valley of coastal Kedah as an early entrepot for the exchange of long-distance trade goods for the forest products of the Malay hinterland. This riverine valley shows evidence of intensive international trade contacts in the second half of the first millennium — trade goods from India and West Asia, together with Chinese ceramics, indicate the nature of this traffic.¹⁰

These trade goods from various parts of Asia have been found in association with Hindu-Buddhist remains, including brick temple structures. The Buddhagupta stele (Fig. 5), discovered in the 1840s at Seberang Perai (Penang, Malaysia), records a message of thanksgiving for safe-passage by a merchant who identifies himself as “the great sea-captain Buddhagupta”. The stele is incised with a *stupa* and bears an inscription indicative of a date from the fifth century or later. Both the *stupa* style and

the script suggest South Indian connections.¹¹ The Bujang Valley also has extensive remains of fired brick shrine and temple structures. The absence of any traces of remains or footings for superstructures suggests that they may have had timber and thatch roofing elements, perhaps resembling the traditional temple architecture of Bali. The emergence of this riverine entrepot, one of the earliest on the Malay Peninsula, mirrors a pattern of settlement occurring at geographically favoured locations along the coastlines which shadowed the East-West maritime trade routes. Imported and locally produced artefacts coexist in the archaeological landscape, making secure identifications sometimes problematic. This is especially the case with religious imagery, in which efforts to distinguish local products from Indian imports sometimes remain inconclusive.

It is perhaps not until the sixth or seventh centuries that we have archaeological evidence for the circulation of Indian Buddhist imagery in Southeast Asia, though it is known that small portable devotional images were carried by pilgrims in earlier centuries. Faxian's travel account provides the earliest confirmation of the portability of such images: when the merchant ship on which he has secured passage from Sri Lanka is caught in a storm, he speaks of his fear that the merchants will throw his sacred books and religious images overboard along with their cargo.¹² Faxian tells us that he prayed to Avalokiteśvara, the Lord of Compassion. The intervention of this Bodhisattva was invoked early in the history of the cult. A representation of Avalokiteśvara in the sixth-century rock-cut shrine at Kanheri (near Mumbai) makes explicit his role as the "patron-saint" of mariners: one of the supplementary scenes depicts sailors in a sinking ship appealing for his intervention (Fig. 6). Votive tablets depicting him in multi-armed forms begin to appear in peninsular Southeast Asia from around the eighth century onwards (Fig. 7).

The best description of seventh-century Indian Buddhism is provided by another Chinese pilgrim, Xuanzang. He wrote a highly revealing account of the state of Buddhism in its homeland, including — unique for this period — glimpses into the daily life of the monastic community and their devotional activities, including forms of relic and *stupa* worship. This was the era of large-scale monastic centres of learning (*maha-vihara*), which also served as centres for the production of Buddhist art of the highest order. Large-scale Buddha sculptures in cast copper-alloy signal this development. In all probability it was these workshops at monasteries in coastal south-eastern India that produced the earliest metal images to circulate in the Southeast Asian Buddhist diaspora. The most notable are the well-known "Sulawesi Buddha" and the Đồng Dương Buddha from

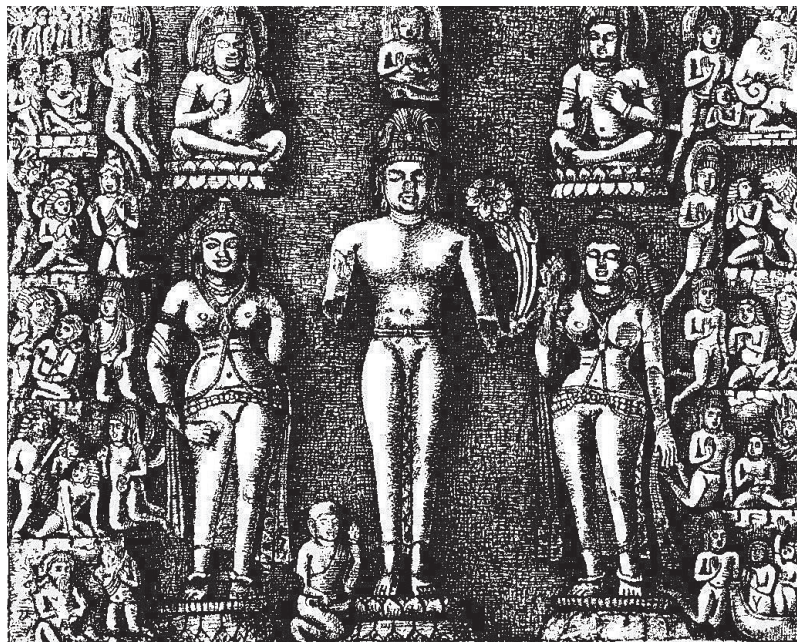


Fig. 6 Rock-cut shrine dedicated to the Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara; Cave 90, Kanheri, Maharashtra, ca. 6th century.
[Line engraving after James Fergusson and James Burgess, *The Cave Temples of India* (London: W.H. Allen & Co., 1880, Plate LV).]



Fig. 7 Moulded devotional icon depicting the twelve-armed Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, with stamped impressions of the *Ye Dharma* verse on the reverse. Terracotta, recovered in the Malay Peninsula. 8th–9th century. (Asian Civilisations Museum, Singapore)



Fig. 8 Buddha preaching. Recovered from the site of the Đồng Dương monastery, Quảng Nam Province, ca. 8th–9th century. Bronze, ht. 119 cm. (Museum of Vietnamese History, Hồ Chí Minh City)

the Cham territories in central Vietnam (Fig. 8). These sculptures in the so-called Post-Amaravati style remain highly controversial in terms of both their origin and their dating. Buddhist workshops in Andhra Pradesh or in neighbouring Sri Lanka in the eighth or ninth century are the most probable origin of these masterpieces.

The period described by Xuanzang was marked by the rising popularity of the more esoteric form of Mahayana Buddhism known as Vajrayana, especially in eastern India. Monastic centres in Bengal and Orissa (Kalinga) were instrumental in these developments — the very regions with the most regular and sustained maritime contacts with insular Southeast Asia. Java was especially receptive, and various forms of Tantric syncretism were fostered there, blending esoteric aspects of Hindu and Buddhist practices. The rise and spread of Vajrayana, evidenced in generously patronized temples and portable imagery and ritual utensils, was closely linked to this cult's popularity in court circles.

Indian *rishi* (ascetics) had long been associated with the emerging courts of Southeast Asia, and no small part of their popularity with local rulers lay in their proclaimed ability to perform charms and various forms of magic. The Telaga Batu inscription from Palembang, mentioned

above, invokes spells and curses against those who would be disloyal, whilst promising “immaculate tantra” and “fruitful peace” (both Mahayana Buddhist aspirations) to those who protect it. This inscription is symptomatic of a climate in which esoteric ritual and the practice of forms of magic were well received. With the advent of Vajrayana Buddhism, these practices were no longer the monopoly of Brahmana *rishi*, but fell within the range of spiritual services offered by Buddhist monks (*bhikkus*) trained in these “advanced skills”.

This development in Buddhism was occurring in a climate of pan-Asian internationalism, encouraged by a rising wave of trade wealth. The circulation of spices, aromatics, resins, pearls and cotton textiles all stimulated the wealth of the region and furthered the consolidation of emerging states. This was an era in which China was demanding the “rare and exotic” and the “strange and precious” — expressions frequently used in the Sui and Tang annals. The forests and seas of Southeast Asia were the principal source of such goods, sold in exchange for silver, silk, copper, cast-iron and ceramics. It is unlikely, of course, that local rulers thought of themselves as part of a region identifiable as “Hindu-Buddhist Southeast Asia”. Rather, as far as we can judge from the limited number of early inscriptions, they appear to have seen themselves as part of an animistic world imbued with newly-imported concepts and sets of imagery belonging to a “Hindu-Buddhist world” which reflected Indian values and ideas.

Part of this process of trade, exchange and assimilation was the circulation of religious images. The early circulation of Buddha images is attested by Southeast Asian finds, especially in Java. A finely modelled late Amaravati-style head of the Buddha found in Java typifies such finds; in all probability it was manufactured in Sri Lanka.¹³ Other images are more clearly non-Indian in origin and must be assumed to have been made in the region in which they were discovered. A solid-cast standing figure of the Buddha in the Victoria and Albert Museum (IS.61-1993), found in the Malay Peninsula and attributable to around the late sixth or seventh century, typifies these products of early local workshops (Fig. 9). This Buddha displays the *abhaya-mudra* gesture, and along with his robust physique and stern countenance, resembles products of the Deccan from a post-Gupta tradition, such as the Buddha from Karnataka.¹⁴

Two small cast-metal Bodhisattva images confirm the South Asian origin of some of the sculptures in circulation. Both are lost-wax cast with a thin body, typical of early (pre-Chola) southern Indian bronzes. They each represent a generic Bodhisattva who does not yet display the standard



Fig. 9 Standing Buddha. Copper alloy.
Malay Peninsula, ca. 7th–8th century.
(Victoria and Albert Museum, London)

iconographic identifiers, namely the seated future Buddha in a head-dress for Avalokiteśvara or the *stupa* for Maitreya. In fact, the *jatamukuta* (coiffure) suggests an identification as Jatamakuta-Lokeśvara, a form of Avalokitesvara. The first image was excavated in the Amaravati territory of Andhra Pradesh (the Krishna River Delta) in eastern India (Fig. 10), the second at Surat Thani in peninsular Thailand. Both may be attributed to the seventh or eighth century and may be from Andhra Pradesh, where the Victoria and Albert example was recovered. Striking parallels with Mahayanist imagery of Sri Lanka raise the real possibility that they are the products of workshops on that island. Sri Lanka in the late first millennium may well have played a larger role in the dissemination of Buddhism and the supply of Buddhist imagery than has been acknowledged to date.



Fig. 10 Bodhisattva Jatamakuta-Lokeśvara.
Recovered from the Krishna River delta, Andhra Pradesh, c. late 7th–8th century. Hollow-cast bronze, ht. 15.2 cm.
(Victoria and Albert Museum, IS. 300–1914)

BUDDHISM IN CHAM TERRITORIES

Royal inscriptions remain the prime source for understanding the religious preferences and the associated ritual practices of early kingdoms in South-east Asia. In Champa the epigraphic record is overwhelmingly dominated by the large corpus of Hindu inscriptions, principally dedicated to Siva. It has been established by Paul Mus that of the 130 Sanskrit- and Cham-language royal inscriptions recorded, only 7 are Buddhist, whilst 92 refer to Siva, 3 to Vishnu, 5 to Brahma and 2 to Harihara.¹⁵ Despite the overwhelmingly Saivite Hindu orientation of the ruling elite of Champa, there is persistent if less overtly public evidence that Buddhism also had an established place in the life of the court and the nobility. Buddhism of both the Hinayana and Mahayana traditions was well enough established in Champa by at least the fifth century, as evidenced by the earliest Cham inscription — from Mỹ Sơn — which identifies the presence of Buddhism in the context of a Saivite sanctuary.¹⁶ The cohabitation of religions which so typically characterizes Indic religious practices in Southeast Asia kingdoms in the later first millennium — early Cambodia and Java in particular — is clearly present in Champa from the beginning of its recorded history.

The earliest dated evidence of Buddhist imagery on the territory of present-day Vietnam is the series of wooden images of the Buddha recovered from water-logged sites in the area of the Mekong Delta associated with the pre-Angkorean “Funan” culture. They have generated RC-14 dates ranging from the early third to the fifth centuries and beyond.¹⁷ Imported Indian and Sri Lankan images, represented by a number of early bronze Buddhas discovered in Thailand such as that found at Nakhon Ratchasima, would have provided ready models for such locally-produced wooden imagery.¹⁸

Traces of early Buddhism can be detected at a number of coastal sites in southern and central Vietnam. The most numerous evidence takes the form of miniature clay devotional icons, produced in multiples as an act of merit-earning by devotees; such clay icons are found widely at seventh- to tenth-century sites in Southeast Asia. A small number of the metal matrices used to produce them have also been discovered, most recently on the tenth-century *Intan* shipwreck in the West Java Sea.¹⁹ No such moulds have yet been recorded from Vietnam, though isolated finds of clay votives have been made in the vicinity of Trà Kiệu (Quảng Nam), and more recently caches have been excavated at Tuy Hoà (Phú Yên) and at Châu Sa, to the north of the Trà Khúc river estuary (Quảng Ngãi)



Fig. 11 Moulded devotional icon depicting seated Buddha flanked by two Bodhisattvas. Terracotta. Part of hoard recovered at a brick citadel site, Châu Sa, overlooking the Trà Khúc river estuary, Quảng Ngãi. (Photograph by the author, 2004)

(Fig. 11). The style of the majority of these votives directly replicates versions associated with Dvaravati sites in peninsular Thailand, sites in lower Burma, and Srivijayan sites on the Malay Peninsula and Sumatra.²⁰

These finds are typically associated with riverine Cham settlements, and may be taken to reflect a level of Buddhist expansion associated with long-distance trade in the later first millennium. It was in this very period, marked by an energetic commercial internationalism, that Buddhism enjoyed a wave of renewed popularity in Asian court circles. Inscriptions commissioned by various rulers provide repeated references to the paramount position that the veneration of the Buddha and saviour cults of the Bodhisattvas and Taras had assumed in the devotional life of the Cham royal circle and elite.²¹ In this climate of pan-Asian Mahayana expansion the cult of the Bodhisattva assumed a special position. The rise in popularity of the cult across Asia in such a short timespan reminds us of just how interconnected the various political centres were through trade and diplomacy. Shared Buddhist imagery is one way of glimpsing the common culture that linked Srivijaya, Java, Cambodia and the Cham territories. The great bronze torso of the Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara recovered from Wat Wiang at Chaiya, near Surat Thani in peninsular Thailand, epitomises the mastery of metal sculpture during this period.²² A lesser work of art from Champa nonetheless shows both an awareness and indebtedness of Srivijayan Buddhist art and its South Indian sources (Fig. 12).

Inscriptions link the cult of the Bodhisattvas to ritual and magical functions central to the political legitimacy and survival of the ruler and his state in which the deities are repeatedly invoked as protectors and

Fig. 12 Bodhisattva, probably Avalokiteśvara.
Unprovenanced, from Cham territories,
c. late 8th–9th century. Copper alloy, ht. 31 cm.
(Museum for Indian Art, Berlin)



benefactors. These are all royal dedicatory inscriptions associated with the foundation or renovation of temples or the consecration of images. The preferred language of these royal dedications is exclusively Sanskrit until the seventh century, when both Sanskrit and Cham are jointly used in a single stele — not to produce a truly bilingual text but rather to convey different content in each language. The religious passages and magical evocations appear in Sanskrit, whilst the Cham language is confined to recording the details of the gifts associated with the dedication, typically itemising the gifts and endowments of land presented for a temple's upkeep. This was still the practice at Mỹ Sơn up to the end of the tenth century.²³ Beginning with the late-fifth-century inscription of King Bhadresvara I at Mỹ Sơn, these rulers referred to themselves as the “kings of Champa”, and it is the distribution of these inscriptions which helps to define the geographical limits of the Cham territories. These rulers were



Fig. 13 Tara. Recovered from the site of the
Đồng Dương monastery, Quảng Nam Province,
9th century. Copper alloy, ht. 115 cm.
(Cham Museum of Đà Nẵng)

consistent in their dedication to Siva as the paramount presiding deity whose beneficence was needed to ensure prosperity in a fragmented and volatile political landscape.²⁴

The epigraphic record is largely silent on the matter of Buddhism and provides little information as to who its patrons were. The notable exception is the Mahayanist monastery founded at Đồng Dương by Indravarman II; its dedicatory stele of 875 celebrates the veneration of the Buddhist deity Lokeśvara under the name “Laksmindra Lokeśvara Svabhayada”. This same inscription also records Indravarman’s recognition of his dependence on Siva’s overarching supremacy, expressed in the donation of a *kosa*, a precious metal *linga* cover “with a golden face”. The cult of Lokeśvara dominated the imagery of Đồng Dương. Unusually, the cult image of the supreme Bodhisattva, in gold or gilt bronze, was probably installed in the principal sanctuary of the central tower; a pedestal platform survives *in situ*.²⁵ The monumental Buddha image seated with both legs pendant, now in the Đà Nẵng Museum, occupied the monks’ *vihara* (meditation hall).

It may be assumed that the principal cult image of the Đồng Dương monastery, undoubtedly made of precious metals, perished in one of the innumerable looting raids which were a regular occurrence in Cham political life. Such conflicts are recorded with increasing frequency in the Đại Việt annals over the centuries. Many Cham inscriptions record the restoration and replenishing of temples, including the dedication of replacement cult images, be they *linga* and *kosa* or anthropomorphic icons of the presiding deity. However, the chance discovery in 1978 of a large bronze female deity in fields near the monastic complex has given a clue as to the style and scale of the lost Lokeśvara (Fig. 13). In all probability, given the preference for the hieratic scaling of images conceived as an ensemble, the Bodhisattva would have been cast on an even larger scale. This Tara figure may be the closest we will get to understanding the appearance of the cult image of Đồng Dương. The plainness of the figures, bare-chested and wearing only a pleated waist-skirt, would have been richly adorned with temple jewellery expressly commissioned for this purpose. Examples of such ornaments, *repoussée* gold work set with semi-precious stones, rock-crystal and glass, have been recovered from many Cham temple sites.²⁶

Nor was Đồng Dương the only Mahayanist establishment in ninth-century Cham territories. An inscription from Đèo Ngang (Quảng Bình), on the boundary between Cham and Chinese-ruled Vietnamese territory, records an unnamed local ruler making donations to a monastery dedicated

to Avalokiteśvara.²⁷ Similarly, the An Thái inscription (902) from Quảng Nam records the earlier construction of a monastery named as “*vihara* Pramuditalokeśvara” which was dedicated to Avalokiteśvara. The presiding abbot — Nagapuspa — is identified by name, as is the royal patron, King Bhadravarman. Specific mention is made of the consecration of an image of Avalokiteśvara, titled “Lokanatha”. The inscription confirms the temple’s foundation endowments and tax exemptions. An inscription dated 911 from Nhan Biều (Quảng Trị) records another dedication of a Buddhist monastery to Avalokiteśvara, by the nobleman Rajadvara, known to have served several Cham kings and to have undertaken two diplomatic missions to Java.²⁸ The Bodhisattva is named as Vrddhalokeśvara, incorporating the name of a female ancestor of the patron; this reflects a tendency in Cham religious practice to increasingly accommodate autochthonous beliefs.

Another inscription, dated to the reign of Jaya Simhavarman (989–903), records the endowment of a shrine and the installation of a silver icon at Vrddha Ratnapura (Quảng Bình); the shrine is dedicated to Ratnalokeśvara. A number of metal images have been recovered from here, including three of Prajñāparamita and two of Avalokiteśvara. The nearby monastic site of Mĩ Đức has also yielded Lokeśvara images. Another Buddhist shrine was dedicated at Kon Klor (in the highland province of Kontum) in 914, and an image named as Mahindralokeśvara consecrated in that year.²⁹

A characteristic of Mahayanist inscriptions of Champa, exemplified by the An Thái dedication, is the stress the eulogies place on spiritual liberation resulting merely from thinking on the supreme Bodhisattva. The cult offered “unalloyed salvation by thinking of Lokeśvara”.³⁰ This is a form of Western Paradise Mahayana in which the Buddha of Infinite Light, with Avalokiteśvara as his worldly agent, can save souls through divine intervention. In the context of this advanced Mahayana thought and ritual practice, it is not difficult to see the special role assigned to the cult of the Bodhisattva of Supreme Compassion.

The Bodhisattva Images

In his pioneering study of Cham art, Jean Boisselier describes a number of Bodhisattva icons found at sites in central and southern Cham territories. They are of relatively small scale and would have served as appropriate objects of veneration for private chapels and for use in secondary shrines. Of the large-scale Bodhisattva images known from the inscriptions to have been made in gold, silver and presumably gilt bronze, none survive, and certainly none that match the *Tangshu*’s description quoted at the

opening of this paper of gold and silver images “ten spans around”. The Đồng Dương bronze and silver Tara, measuring 39.5 cm, gives us a clue as to the scale of such icons. The dedicatory stele inscription of Indravarman II records that in 875 the king founded the *vihara* and temple “for the benefit of the community of monks (*sangha*)” and “had made the Lokeśvara [image]”.³¹ Yet all of this eulogizing of the Bodhisattva of Infinite Compassion took place in a religious environment presided over — according to the inscription — by a supreme protector, Siva. The Buddha and associated Bodhisattvas are thus seen as saviours existing within a larger religious system. This is a form of the Siva-Buddha syncretism familiar from Java and, to a lesser extent, Cambodia.

A number of copper-alloy cast images representing Bodhisattvas have recently come to light, signalling again the importance of these cults. Their provenances are unclear, but it must be assumed that they were recovered by illicit diggers, principally in Quảng Nam. The quality and condition of these objects compare very favourably with those preserved in historical collections. A group of three unprovenanced Bodhisattva images were reported recovered together: a magnificent Avalokiteśvara Padmapani, complete with flaming cusped aureole; a second Padmapani of smaller scale; and a Vajrapani (Fig. 14). Each figure is standing on a raised and waisted lotus pedestal of similar type. The figures show traces of mercury gilding, best preserved on the larger Padmapani. The Padmapanis are both four-armed, holding in their upper hands a manuscript (*pustaka*) and a rosary (*aksamala*), and in the lower hands a holy water vessel (*kamandalu/kundika*) and a lotus flower and stem (*padma*). The larger Avalokiteśvara Padmapani is the most elaborate ensemble recovered to date. The figure bears close comparison in both style and scale with the fine example from Quảng Bình (Fig. 15), but the latter lacks the wondrous openwork back-plate. The newly discovered icon displays for the first time the true splendour of such complete compositions.

The style and adornment of these figures bear close comparison with such figure-types from the Srivijayan world. The types of body jewellery worn point to South India and Sri Lanka as providing the models for this image. Note the style of torque, floral-boss arm-bands worn high on the upper arm, and the pectoral band across his chest and waist-belt, both displaying elaborate workmanship. All of these features no doubt replicated the type of princely jewellery in circulation at this time. The chest-belt was a decorative element particularly favoured in Pallava South India. The elaborate aureole which envelopes the entire figure has a sinuously cusped profile, with floral bosses on the nimbus framing the saviour’s head. It is



Fig. 14 Group of Cham Buddhist icons, the Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara Padmapani flanked by Vajrapani and another image of Padmapani. Cham territories, late 9th–10th century. Gilt copper alloy, heights 33, 56, 54 cm. (Douglas Latchford Collection, London)



Fig. 15 Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara as Padmapani, recovered from Đại Hữu, Quảng Bình Province, 10th century. Copper alloy, ht. 54 cm. (Museum of Vietnamese History, Hồ Chí Minh City)



Fig. 16 Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara. Unprovenanced, from Cham territories, 9th–10th century. Gold and silver sheet over ceramic core, ht. 45 cm. (Private collection, Hong Kong)

enlivened by highly elaborated flames, which add drama and energy to the figure, and are set in counterpoint to the supreme meditative composure of the Bodhisattva himself. He wears an elaborate header (*jatamukuta*), with plaits of hair piled up and cascading to left and right. At the centre of the diadem sits the Amitabha Buddha, the Bodhisattva's spiritual mentor.

In both conception and execution, this complete Padmapani ensemble may usefully be compared to Bodhisattva icons from the Dali kingdom of Yunnan. Through a complex process of cross-fertilization and exchange, I think we are here witnessing in the Cham version a blending of inherited Indian models with newer elements of regional styles of contemporary Buddhist art, including from China proper and, as I have attempted to demonstrate elsewhere, from Yunnan.³² This is an image of great spiritual authority, embodying the deity's sublimely compassionate nature. The sophistication with which these subtle qualities have been realised sets this object apart as one of the masterpieces of Cham Buddhist art.

The smaller and incomplete Padmapani has a sweetness of expression we would tend to associate more with the Buddhist art of Srivijaya and especially Java. Nevertheless, its shared physical characteristics with the Vajrapani, which one could say is more "ethnically Cham", establish beyond reasonable doubt a Cham origin for both icons. The Vajrapani, clenching in his raised hand a double-ended *vajra*, is represented as a menacingly presence, wielding his magical weapon in defence of the faith. He is the principal Bodhisattva of the *vajra* assembly of deities, presided over by the Dhyani-Buddha Aksobhya. This image was found to contain in its base a small sheet of gold foil with incised Indian letters, presumably a *mantra* or *dharani* — magical charms to generate mystic power — introduced to enhance the efficacy of the icon.³³ Several of the seated Bodhisattvas from Đồng Dương hold a four-sided attribute which I would suggest is intended to represent a *vajra*, suggesting their identification with Vajrapani. The same weapon is wielded by the mighty *Dvarapalas* (gate keepers) of Đồng Dương monastery, further supporting the idea of an overarching Vajrayana orientation for the esoteric Buddhism practised there which awaits further investigation.³⁴ A stone sculpture of Vajrapani's spiritual parent-mentor Aksobhya, represented as a meditative yogi with a *vajra* placed before him, survives from the same monastery. Aksobhya is associated with the eastern direction in *maha-mandala* configurations, and may be presumed to have served this function at that monastery.

The final image to introduce is a standing Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara modelled in gold sheet (for the upper body and feet) and silver sheet for the waist-shirt (Fig. 16). The thin-section metal is modelled over low-fired

clay core, itself constructed around an iron armature.³⁵ The modelling is relatively crude but nonetheless pleasing; the decorative use of contrasting metals is a particularly successful device. The figure is two-armed only, and in this and some other decorative treatments resembles more the Yunnanese icons of the Dali kingdom than their Cham counterparts. In a cavity in the head two small gold foil sheets were recovered, with traces of a script incised into the surface. Although these have proved illegible, they may be assumed to carry *mantras* or *dharanis* to enhance the efficacy of the image. Such a practice was common throughout the Buddhist world, and was especially prevalent in Java, a region closely linked to the Cham kingdoms in this period.

These newly revealed Buddhist sculptures serve to extend our knowledge of the state of Buddhist art and patronage in Cham territories at the close of the first millennium. The demonstrable popularity of the cult of the Bodhisattva Lokeśvara in particular sheds light on the specific character of Southeast Asian Buddhism as practised by the royal households of Champa and its relationship to the Pan-Asian Buddhism of the period.

Notes

1. Hiram Woodward, "Esoteric Buddhism in Southeast Asia in the light of recent scholarship", *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies* 35, 2 (2004): 329–30; see also R.M. Davidson, *Indian Esoteric Buddhism: A Social History of the Tantric Movement* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2002).
2. J.G.de Casparis, *Prasasti Indonesia II: Selected Inscriptions from the 7th to the 9th Century* (Bandung: Masa Baru, 1956) and Hermann Kulke, "'Kadatuan Srivijaya' — Empire or Kraton of Srivijaya? A Reassessment of the Epigraphical Evidence", *Bulletin de l'Ecole Française d'Extrême-Orient* (henceforth *BEFEO*) 80 (1993): 159–81.
3. Ian W. Mabbett, "Buddhism in Champa", in *Southeast Asia in the 9th to 14th Centuries*, ed. David Marr and Anthony Milner (Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 1986), p. 295.
4. *Su O* tale, quoted in Edward H. Schafer, *The golden peaches of Samarkand: A study of T'ang exotics* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1965), p. 195.
5. *Tangshu*, quoted in Edward H. Schafer, *The vermilion bird: T'ang images of the south* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1967), p. 72.
6. I-Tsing [Yijing], *A record of the Buddhist religion as practised in the Malaya Archipelago (AD 671–695)*, tr. J. Takakusu (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1896), p. 12.

7. A number of such bronze model *stupa* are preserved in the Government Museum at Chennai; illustrations can be found in T.N. Ramachandran, "The Nagapattinam and other Buddhist Bronzes in the Madras Museum", *Bulletin of the Madras Government Museum* 7, 1 (1954): pls. XII–XVII.
8. See Peter Skilling, "Traces of the Dharma: Preliminary Reports on some *ye dharma* and *ya dharma* inscriptions from mainland Southeast Asia", *BEFEO* 90–1 (2003–4): 273–87, and John Guy, "Échanges artistiques et relations interrégionales dans les territoires Cham", in *Trésors d'art du Vietnam. La sculpture du Champa, V^e–XV^e siècles*, ed. Pierre Baptiste and Thierry Zéphir (Paris: Musée Guimet, 2005), pp. 145–6.
9. D.C. (Dinesh Chandra) Sircar, "Date of the earliest Sanskrit inscription of Campa", *Indian Historical Quarterly* 17, 1 (1941): 107–110.
10. Nik Hassan Shuhaimi Nik Abdul Rahman and Othman Mohd. Yatim, *Antiquities of Bujang Valley* (Kuala Lumpur: Museum Association of Malaysia, 1990).
11. John Guy, "South Indian Buddhism and its Southeast Asian legacy", in *Cultural interface of India with Asia: Religion, art and architecture*, ed. Anupa Pande and Parul Pandya Dhar (New Delhi: National Museum Institute Monographs Series, 2004), pp. 155–75.
12. Fa Hien (Faxian), *Fa Hien, A record of Buddhistic kingdoms being an account by the Chinese monk Fa-Hien of his travels in India and Ceylon (A.D. 399–414) in search of the Buddhist Books of Discipline*, tr. John Legge (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1886), p. 112.
13. Guy, "South Indian Buddhism".
14. John Guy, "Southern Buddhism — traces and transmissions", in *Proceedings of the 16th European Association of South Asian Archaeology Conference, Collège de France, Paris, 2001*, ed. Catherine Jarrige (Paris: L'Harmattan, 2005), pp. 495–504, Figs. 4 and 5.
15. Paul Mus, *India seen from the East. Indian and indigenous cults in Champa*, tr. I.W. Mabbett (Melbourne: Monash Papers on Southeast Asia, 1975), p. 3.
16. *Ibid.*, pp. 3–4.
17. Vo Si Khai, "The kingdom of Fu Nan and the cultures of Oc Eo", in *Art and archaeology of Fu Nan: Pre-Khmer kingdom of the Lower Mekong valley*, ed. James C.M. Khoo (Bangkok: Orchid Press, 2003), p. 85.
18. Illustrated in National Museum Volunteers, *The artistic heritage of Thailand* (Bangkok: Sawaddi, 1979), p. 17.
19. John Guy, "Offering up a rare jewel: Buddhist merit-making and votive tablets in early Burma", in *Burma: Art and archaeology*, ed. Alexandra Green and T. Richard Blurton (London: British Museum Press, 2002), pp. 23–33; Michael Flecker, *The archaeological excavation of the 10th century Intan shipwreck* (Oxford: Archaeopress, 2002); Guy, "The Intan shipwreck: A 10th century cargo in South-east Asian waters", in *Song ceramics: Art history*,

- archaeology and technology*, ed. Stacey Pierson (London: SOAS, Percival David Foundation of Chinese Art Colloquies on Art and Archaeology in Asia, 2004), pp. 171–92.
20. Trần Kỳ Phương, personal communication. Other votives are illustrated in Guy, “Offering up a rare jewel”.
 21. See *Études épigraphiques sur le pays cham*, ed. Claude Jacques (Paris: École Française d’Extrême-Orient, 1995).
 22. Illustrated in Piriya Krairiksh, *Art in peninsular Thailand prior to the fourteenth century A.D.* (Bangkok: Fine Arts Department, 1980), pl. 30.
 23. A series of inscriptions in which the use of the Cham language appears between the years 875 and 972 is provided by Geoffrey E. Marrison, “The Early Cham language, and its relationship to Malay”, *Journal of the Malaysian Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society* 48, 2 (1975): 54–8. For a broader discussion of the relationship between Sanskrit- and local-language epigraphy, see Sheldon Pollock, “The Sanskrit cosmopolis, 300–1300: Transculturation, vernacularization, and the question of ideology”, in *Ideology and status of Sanskrit: Contributions to the history of the Sanskrit language*, ed. Jan E.M. Houben (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1996), pp. 197–247.
 24. The territorial parameters of “Champa” in this early period are difficult to define but seem to be centred around the area in present-day Quảng Nam which later became known as Amaravati (what could be considered as “Northern Champa”), stretching from Mỹ Sơn in the hills to Trà Kiệu on the hinterland and out to the coast. Other centres were evidently active, but it is not clear whether they had emerged as distinct political entities at this point in time.
 25. Jean Boisselier, *La statuaire du Champa. Recherches sur les cultes et l’iconographie* (Paris: École Française d’Extrême-Orient, 1963), pp. 91 and 122; for a discussion of *linga-kosa*, see John Guy, “The kosa masks of Champa: New evidence”, in *Southeast Asian archaeology 1998*, ed. Wibke Lobo and Stefanie Reimann (Hull: Ethnology Museum State Museum of Berlin and University of Hull, 2000), pp. 51–60.
 26. The bronze is illustrated in Boisselier, *Statuaire*, fig. 70. Regrettably little of the gold work found at these sites is ever reported; historically it was melted down for new jewellery, and today increasingly finds its way onto the antiquities market; see Lê Xuân Diệm and Vũ Kim Lộc, *Cổ vật Champa/ Artefacts of Champa* (Hanoi: Văn hoá dân tộc, 1996).
 27. Mabbett, “Buddhism in Champa”, p. 300.
 28. The An Thái inscription is in R.C. Majumdar, *Ancient Indian colonies in the Far East*, vol. 1 (Champa) (Dacca: A.K. Majumdar, 1927), pp. 105–9. On the Nhan Biều inscription, see Édouard Huber, “Études indochinoises, XII: L’épigraphie de la dynastie de Đồng-Dương”, *BEFEO* 11 (1911): 299–311, cited in Mabbett, “Buddhism in Champa”, p. 302.

29. Boisselier, *Statuaire*, fig. 70 (Vrddha Ratnapura) and pp. 133–6 (Mĩ Đứrc); Louis Finot, “Lokesvara en Indochine”, *Études Asiatiques*, vol. 1 (Paris: École Française d’Extrême-Orient, 1925), p. 234 (Kon Klor).
30. Mabbett, “Buddhism in Champa”, p. 301, quoting the text of the An Thái inscription.
31. *Ibid.*, p. 300.
32. John Guy, “The Avalokiteśvara of Yunnan and some South East Asian connections”, in *South East Asia and China: Art, interaction and commerce*, ed. Rosemary Scott and John Guy (London: Percival David Foundation of Chinese Art, 1994), pp. 64–83.
33. This inscription awaits translation.
34. Illustrated in Baptiste and Zephir, ed., *Trésors d’art du Vietnam*, pp. 224–9.
35. In order to stabilize this sculpture, the investigating conservator removed the armature and core material, replacing it with an inert resin.